8 Iraq and the West 1988–2008

POINTS TO CONSIDER

Despite suffering massive destruction and losing half a million lives in the war with Iran that ended in 1988, Saddam Hussein led his country to war again in 1990–1. This time, and then again in 2003, he found himself at war with the West, in particular with the USA, the superpower that now dominated the Middle East. Saddam's government was overthrown in 2003 yet liberation was to lead to foreign occupation and chaos. These developments are covered in this chapter under the following headings:

- Iraq, Kuwait and the Gulf War 1990–1
- The UN, the USA and the invasion of Iraq 2003
- Occupation, chaos and reconstruction in Iraq 2003–8

Key dates

1988		Iraqi forces attacked Halabja with chemical weapons
1990	August	Iraqi invasion of Kuwait
1991	Jan–March	First Gulf War
2000		Election of George W. Bush as US President
2001		Attack on the World Trade Center in New York
2002		Return of UN weapons inspectors to Iraq
2003		Invasion of Iraq – the Second Gulf War

1 | Iraq, Kuwait and the Gulf War 1990–1

Saddam Hussein and the Kurds

Key question
What was Saddam's 'Kurdish problem' and how did he solve it?

When the war with Iran ended in 1988, the Iraqi government promised the people peace and prosperity. What they got was further hardship and more terror. Instead of rebuilding Iraq, Saddam kept a million men in arms and poured money into developing the most advanced weapons. Against whom did he plan to use them? His immediate enemies were inside Iraq.

The Kurds form about 20 per cent of the population of Iraq. They are Muslims but not Arab and they speak a different